it as regressive identity politics. They invoked the spectre of national disunity. But, behind the scenes, alarm bells had begun ringing in the BJP camp. The party's strategists could not have missed what an Azim Premji University study had found in 2018: 55 per cent of Indian voters prefer a leader of their caste. In August 2021, at a book launch function in Delhi, RSS *sarkaryavah* (general secretary) Dattatreya Hosabale publicly endorsed the need for a caste census to ensure benefits reached the "most backward among the backward". This was a watershed moment, a formal acknowledgment of caste's role in social equity by the Sangh's top ranks. As Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan puts it, "Social harmony requires systemic reform. You can't undo centuries of deprivation in just 78 years of independence. A caste survey will help us understand the exact composition of society, which in turn will enable better policy."

COME ONE, COME ALL

In the general elections of 2014 and 2019, the BJP's triumphs were built on transcending caste equations through a mix of Hindu nationalist appeal, welfare schemes and sheer organisational muscle. Embracing a caste census allows the BJP to pivot its narrative, from just 'Hindus vs others' to include 'justice for backward communities within the Hindu fold'. Modi now has the opportunity to position himself as a champion of the OBCs on his own terms. BJP spokespersons have begun spotlighting the party's record to reinforce this image: the Modi government has implemented 27 per cent OBC reservation in NEET, granted constitutional status to the National Commission for Backward Classes in 2018, and boasts the highest number of OBC MPs and ministers in history. These points aim to reassure OBC voters that the BJP is no longer the upper caste-dominated party of the past but a broad-based platform that represents their aspirations. Political scientist Ashutosh Kumar observes, "The BJP doesn't want to be the party of Hindus. It wants to be the party of every Hindu."

The party's decision to back a caste census also serves to strengthen its ties within the NDA, where many allies rely on support from specific caste groups. In Uttar Pradesh, Apna Dal draws heavily from Kurmi OBC voters, while the Nishad Party represents the fisherfolk community. In Rajasthan, the Rashtriya Loktantrik Party appeals to certain OBC segments. These allies have welcomed the caste census, as it aligns with their politics of caste-based representation.

Even former rivals now aligned with the BJP have shown long-standing interest in caste data—Nitish Kumar raced ahead with a caste survey in Bihar, and Ajit Pawar in Maharashtra is keen on securing benefits for Marathas. By endorsing the caste census, the BJP has not only validated their demands but also reinforced the NDA's relevance in the social justice discourse. This move helps reassure allies that the BJP is committed to retaining this political space, rather than leaving it to the Opposition.

Critics have long held that backward Muslims and Christians deserve as much recognition as Hindu OBCs. Activists like Faiyaz Ahmad Fyzie demand a caste census that includes Muslim OBCs, SCs and STs. In the Supreme Court, West Bengal is defending its 2010-12 addition of 77 OBC communities—75 of them Muslim—which the BJP has sharply criticised. Many states include Muslim OBCs in their reservation lists, but the Centre's list remains narrow, often clubbing backward Muslim groups with privileged Ashrafs. Modi has often framed their marginali-

THE CASTE SPIRAL

1931 → The last caste census in India, which put the OBCs at 52% of the population

1979 → Mandal Commission uses 1931 data to propose 27% OBC reservation; in 1990, V.P. Singh government okays quota

2011 → Nationwide Socio-Economic Caste Census is conducted, but results under wraps

2014 → Telangana (2014) and Andhra Pradesh (2016-17) carry out Aadhaar-linked household surveys, collect caste/ economic data. Again, findings remain unpublished

2015 → Karnataka's 2015 socio-economic survey results put on ice till CM Siddaramaiah's return. Results accepted in 2025, but not publicised yet

2018 → In 2018, the Centre promises caste enumeration in the 2021 Census, but all assurances lost in pandemic convulsions. Even the Census is delayed

2023 → Bihar releases caste survey results in 2023; Odisha announces a similar effort

2025 → In Feb. 2025, Telangana releases a Socio-Economic, Educational, Employment, Political and Caste Survey report



"Affirmative action isn't about vote-bank politics. It's about accountability and justice.... Our initiatives are aimed at removing poverty, not reshaping cultural identities"

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN
Union minister of education, and senior BJP leader